

²⁷ See Bernard F. Engel, *Marianne Moore* (New York: Twayne Publishers, 1964), pp. 118–29, Donald Hall, *Marianne Moore: The Cage and the Animal* (New York: Pegasus, 1970), pp. 114–23, and Laurence Stapleton, *Marianne Moore: The Poet's Advance* (Princeton: Princeton Univ. Press, 1978), pp. 158–183.

²⁸ Wallace Fowle notes Moore's "outstanding technical achievement" in "The American Word for La Fontaine," *The New York Times Book Review*, May 16, 1964, p. 1. Hugh Kenner suggests that the translation "succeeds astonishingly" in "Supreme in Her Abnormality," *Poetry*, 84 (1954), 356–63.

²⁹ "A Few Bricks from Babel" in *Marianne Moore: A Collection of Critical Essays*, ed. Tomlinson (Englewood Cliffs, New Jersey: Prentice Hall, 1969), p. 134.

³⁰ *Poetry New York*, 4 (1951), 7.

³¹ *Ibid.*, 9.

³² *Ibid.*, 8.

³³ The term is Moore's. See "An Interview with Donald Hall" in Tomlinson, p. 29.

³⁴ *The Collected Poems of Wallace Stevens* (New York: Alfred Knopf, 1975), p. 76.

³⁵ Cited in Vivienne Koch, *William Carlos Williams* (Norfolk, Connecticut: New Directions, 1950), p. 38.

³⁶ In *The Imagist Poem*, ed. Pratt (New York: E. P. Dutton & Co., 1963), p. 79.

³⁷ A copy of the lecture is located in the Marianne Moore Collection at the Rosenbach Museum and Library, Philadelphia.

³⁸ "Albino and Motley in 'The Sycamore,'" *Marianne Moore Newsletter*, 3, 2 (1979), 8–10.

³⁹ *The Collected Poems of Wallace Stevens*, pp. 9–10.

⁴⁰ *The Imagist Poem*, p. 84.

⁴¹ *Contact*, 4 (1921), 5.

⁴² *Poetry*, 44 (1934), 103–06.

⁴³ *Poetry New York*, 4 (1951), 7.

⁴⁴ Moore Collection, Rosenbach Museum.

⁴⁵ *Goethes Werke* (Weimar: H. Böhlau, 1887–1919), 1, 2, p. 216.

⁴⁶ *Poems, North & South—A Cold Spring* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1955), pp. 89–90.

⁴⁷ See Ralph Rees, "The Armor of Marianne Moore," *Bucknell Review*, 7 (1957), 27–40.

⁴⁸ *The Lantern*, 18 (1910), 102.

⁴⁹ "Forward" to *A Marianne Moore Reader* (New York: Viking 1961), xvi.

⁵⁰ Moore Collection, Rosenbach, 1250/6/53.

⁵¹ See Thomas Noel, *Theories of the Fable in the Eighteenth Century* (New York: Columbia Univ. Press, 1975).

⁵² "Supreme in Her Abnormality" in Tomlinson, p. 139.

⁵³ See "The Archaeology of Culture," Chapter Three of my dissertation *Fables from the Peaceable Kingdom: The Poetry of Marianne Moore* (*Dissertation Abstracts*, 1982) for an examination of Moore's critique of man's disjunction from the natural world and his subversion of the vision of the Golden Age.

⁵⁴ *Observations* (New York: The Dial Press, 1924), p. 22.

After *The Fables*: The Translator as Poet

ROSALIE SPROUT

There is a touch of La Fontaine, for better or worse, in everything Marianne Moore wrote after the *Fables*. Her later critical essays such as "Subject, Predicate, Object" and "Idiosyncrasy and Technique" use examples from the translations to illustrate poetic principles like "straight writing" and "concentration." Her later poems with their elements of fantasy and their concern for the preservation of American cultural artifacts in rhyme recall La Fontaine's fanciful fables, composed for specific occasions and personalities in seventeenth-century France. The end-rhymes of later poems and their appeal in general to the ear can be traced to the weeks, months, and years spent with La Fontaine's fables and cannot be fully apprehended nor appreciated outside the context of her intense work from 1945 to 1954 on these translations.

Most readers of Moore's poetry either skip the *Fables* altogether, or are familiar only with the ones included in the incomplete *Complete Poems* or the *Marianne Moore Reader*. Some critics have complained that since Marianne Moore admitted she could not speak French nor understand spoken French very well, she had no business tackling the project in the first place. John Ciardi sighed with regret that the poet had attempted translation at all rather than reworking the old fables herself, much as La Fontaine had done.¹ Helen Vendler cautions that "Not a great deal should be claimed for them."² Even Moore's friend and advocate, Laurence Stapleton, sees the *Fables* as a "detour," although Stapleton believes "that some of her finest work is in the book, and that the nature of the task invested her with skills different from those of her earlier poetry."³ Stapleton advances the idea of forward progress in her study of the poet's career, and says that after the fables Moore "came back from the detour to her own road forward."⁴

Nine years of work, even in the career of a long-lived poet, would seem too significant to be considered merely a "detour." We should be more interested in the road taken by Moore than in the one not taken. In addition to working on her translations during those years, Moore also wrote some new poems and revised others for the *Collected Poems* (1951) which won her the Bollingen, the National Book Award for Poetry and a Pulitzer. A variorum edition of Moore's poems would help to illumine just what impact, if any, her work as a translator had on her later revisions.

The *Fables* have had their defenders and admirers. T. S. Eliot undertook the publication of *Selected Fables* by Faber and Faber in England. (He felt that there was not enough of an audience in England to warrant publication of the complete *Fables*.) Hugh Kenner cited the "miraculous" nature of all convincing translation, and called Moore's *Fables* "the work of a deliberate and indefatigable intelligence, which earns its reward when the translator's special diction, personal and by existing literary standards impure, re-creates the French aplomb with an absoluteness no careful reader is going to ascribe to luck."⁵ And John Ashbery wrote: "These are among the truly miraculous works of our time, and ought to be required reading for every beginning poet."⁶

George Steiner uses Moore's translations as an example of successful alchemy—the recreation of a poem's meaning and form in another language for another time. He admires Moore's creative solutions to certain problems posed by translating La Fontaine's French into English. "The cunning plainness of the *Fables*, La Fontaine's admixture of colloquial with neo-classical modes, exactly suited Marianne Moore's gifts."⁷

Moore was fifty-eight years old and an established American poet when she undertook the long and arduous task, thereby reversing Ezra Pound's prescription of translation as a valuable exercise for beginning poets. (Perhaps because he had learned this way, Pound regularly advised novice poets to learn their craft by doing translation.) But the circumstances of Moore's life conspired to make her work on La Fontaine's fables fulfill a different function. Besides giving her the momentum to continue writing at a point in her life when she needed a literary task, the process of translation had a disintegrative as well as an integrative impact on her later poetry.

Although there is much to admire in Bonnie Costello's study of Marianne Moore's poems, it is hard to agree that much of the "late work lacks sincerity and gusto."⁸ Rather, the later poems are a continuation of Moore's search for and celebration of the *genuine* in

American life. These poems *are* different from the earlier ones, but it is premature to say they represent a "falling off" of Moore's poetic genius. She is picking and choosing those things she hopes to preserve, often for a larger, more public audience. Her concern for the moral, social, and cultural fabric of the nation expresses itself in "Love in America?," a poem advocating passion in terms of tenderness and sincerity, "Camperdown Elm," a poem to save a tree, "Carnegie Hall: Rescued," a poem to save a building, and "Rescue with Yul Brynner," a poem about saving people. If Moore is less of a "poet's poet" in these poems, it is because her audience changed and she remembered "that we/ do not admire what/ we cannot understand."⁹ Usefulness and understanding were always part of Moore's aesthetic, but are most prevalent in some of the later poetry.

Marianne Moore's "poetic method," which she said depended on finding a "felicitous phrase"¹⁰ from friends' conversations or her reading and then building a collage of other "flies in amber" that she imbued with her own special meaning, was reversed in the process of translating the *Fables*. Unsure of her French and her ability to understand La Fontaine's meaning in some instances (and therefore appealing to her committee of helpers: Ezra Pound, Harry Levin, Monroe Engel, Malcolm Cowley), she had to *create* her own felicitous phrase to translate La Fontaine's meaning into a poem for a contemporary American/English audience. That she also chose to reproduce La Fontaine's rhyme scheme and rhythms was both a special challenge and a handicap. English has fewer rhymes than French, and the elegant feminine rhymes of French are especially difficult to manage in English without becoming predictable or singsong.

Just as she embellished La Fontaine's fables with visual metaphors and similes, moral comment and her own special point of view, La Fontaine's verse form and content exerted their dynamic presence on her poetic sensibility. In 1966, John Ashbery thought "her new, tough simplicity . . . might be the result of the discipline imposed by her La Fontaine translations."¹¹ More recently, Laurence Stapleton has noted the amount of fantasy in later poems, starting with "Apparition of Splendor" and "Then the Ermine."¹²

I would suggest that in addition to simplicity and fantasy, the experience of translating La Fontaine provided the poet with some "felicitous phrases" for new poems, and that her use of rhyme in the later poems differs from its use in poems before the *Fables*. The rhyme in these later poems is more regular, more musical. It is as if the experience of the eye that is so vivid in the chiseled stanzas of the earlier

poems has been partially relinquished in order to emphasize the experience of the ear.

Among other things, the experience of translation reinforced Moore's own early and lifelong interest in music, one which has not been as thoroughly explored by scholars as her interest in the visual arts. Her fondness for music stems from early childhood. There is an anecdote in which Moore recalls being put to sleep at night by the music box which was in her mother's family.¹³ As an adult, Moore enjoyed going to concerts with her mother, and her appointment books list the programs for specific radio broadcasts of music. She kept a special notebook from 1932-1954 in which she collected quotations about music such as "You have been listening to a fugue by Bach, and Bach is not easy to play"—mixed in with her own observations.¹⁴ Laid into the notebook are newspaper clippings, reviews, programs from concerts at the Brooklyn Institute of Arts and Sciences, a photograph of Walter Gieseking with a biographical sketch of him, and a program from a concert/lecture on "The Music of China."

In the later poems, as in the translations, the *sounds* of words are often as important as their meanings. One thinks especially of such poems as "To Victor Hugo of My Crow Pluto" and "Avec Ardeur." The late poem, "Mercifully," has the relationship between poetry and music for its subject.

An elate tongue is music. . . .
the plain truth—complex truth—
in which unnatural emphases,
"passi-on" and "divis-i-on,"
sound natural. Play it all; *do*;
except in uproars of conversation.

Celestial refrain. . . . My mind
hears it again. Without music
life is flat—bare existence.

The emphasis here is on sounding "natural," even though poetry, including poetry in translation, requires artifice to make its music.

There is a sense, of course, in which Moore is not a poet who had distinct periods. Unlike Yeats, whose early and later poetry can be separated very neatly, her work is all of a piece with characteristics uniquely hers and identifiable throughout everything she ever wrote. All of her poems are written in her special diction with its combination of the formal and the colloquial, hyphenated complex noun phrases, alliteration, quotations, foreign words and phrases, verbal wit and descriptive skill. Most of her poems, both early and late, are written in

regular stanzas with some rhyme. The kind and quality of rhyme, however, change during and after her intimate encounter with La Fontaine's fables.

In earlier poems such as "To A Steam Roller," "Pedantic Literalist," "To Statecraft Embalmed," "The Fish," "The Plumet Basilisk," and "The Frigate Pelican," rhyme is used but often it is in run-on lines which make the rhyme less obvious. Her use of rhyme in these early poems is innovative, never conspicuous or obtrusive.

Eliot called Moore "the greatest living master" of the light rhyme.¹⁵ That was in 1935, ten years before her work on the *Fables*. Eliot distinguishes between "light" and "heavy" rhyme according to how the rhyme establishes its pattern in a poem, against the patterns of metric and sense. The rhymes in "The Steeple-Jack," "The Hero," "The Jerboa," "Camellia Sabina," "Virginia Britannia," "Spenser's Ireland," and "The Pangolin" qualify in Eliot's sensible terms as light rhymes. They give a form and pattern to the poems other than that of the metric and sense, but do not call attention to themselves as elements of conspicuous style. Sometimes, as in "Spenser's Ireland" and "The Pangolin," the use of near-rhymes (or off-rhymes) such as "made" and "said," "scale" and "central" accounts for "lightness" of effect.

At other times, her innovative use of rhyme involves using articles as rhyming words:

an
injured fan
("The Fish")

or breaking words into syllables:

determination's totem. Out-
lawed? His sweet fact and powerful feet go about
("The Wood-Weasel")

or parts of a hyphenated compound:

the little rubber-plant-
leaves of *kok-saghyz*-stalks, can't
("Nevertheless")

. . . the innocent, rare, gold-
defending dragon that as you look begins to be a
nervous naked sword on little feet, with threefold
("The Plumet Basilisk").

There are many run-on lines in these earlier poems. In 1950, however, with the publication of "Armor's Undermining Modesty"¹⁶ we begin to see the use of more conventional rhyme, and the rhythm of the poem's lines is determined by the end-rhymes. To be sure, this poem still has

elements of Marianne Moore's "light" rhyme style: run-on lines, near-rhymes, and contrived compounds, such as "mis-set" and "alphabet." But there is also evidence of more end-stopped end-rhymes:

At first I thought a pest
Must have alighted on my wrist.
It was a moth almost an owl,
Its wings were furred so well,

Arise for it is day.
Even gifted scholars lose their way

give me diatribes and the fragrance of iodine,
the cork oak acorn grown in Spain;
the pale-ale-eyed impersonal look
Which the sales-placard gives the bock beer buck.

I should, I confess,
like to have a talk with one of them about excess,
and armor's undermining modesty
instead of innocent depravity.

In this poem there are also a number of unstressed feminine end-rhymes: "etymology" and "poetry," "pattern" and "Persian," "fashion" and "addition," "excessive" and "preventive," "modesty" and "depravity" which are characteristic of end-rhymes in the La Fontaine translations.

This tendency towards more conspicuous or regular rhyme is a feature of many of Moore's later poems. When it is excessive, as in "Values in Use," "Hometown Piece for Messrs. Alston and Reese," "Enough," or "To Victor Hugo of My Crow Pluto," it tends to be as seemingly frivolous as the subject matter of these poems. At least one critic has suggested that the verse in these poems is rhymed doggerel.¹⁷ With the possible exception of "Enough," the form is appropriate for the whimsy of the subject matter. And in "Enough," which discusses the disappearance of the Jamestown settlement, the poet even self-mockingly comments on the use of rhyme here as somehow inappropriate to the poem's subject matter:

(Don't speak in rhyme
of maddened men in starving-time)

This poem comes across as one tossed off in the manner of La Fontaine to satisfy the occasion, the three hundred and fiftieth anniversary of the Jamestown settlement.

In the years after the *Fables*, Moore appears to have been thinking habitually in rhyme, and one cannot discount the evidence, too, that many of her later poems were "occasional" ones—ones which were requested of or suggested to her as a public celebrity, a famous American poet. It is always more difficult to be creative or original on demand, though there is evidence in her diaries and journals that most of the later poems contain ideas or phrases that Moore had recorded years before the occasion afforded an opportunity to put them into a poem. It may be that in the early poems, "Ecstasy affords / the occasion and expediency determines the form,"¹⁸ but in the later ones occasion came before ecstasy, and therefore, something less than ecstasy informs them. If some of the later poems seem "silly" or "frivolous" by comparison with earlier ones, it is in part because the relationship between Moore and her audience changed after she became "public property," Brooklyn's poet-laureate. And the kind of rhyming she was doing in the translations was appropriate for her later, light verse.

In the later poems, there are more end-stopped end-rhymes. And the *kinds* of rhyming words are reminiscent of Moore's work on the *Fables*. There are many rhyming adverbs and words ending with the long "e" sound: "plainly," "supposedly," "company," "festivity," "rosemary," "differently," "originally" in "Rosemary"; "apparently," "quality," "identically" in "Combat Cultural"; "Tyranny," "ingenuity," "deformity," "priority," "recently," "harmony," "perspicacity," "actuality" in "Granite and Steel"; "diversity," "persistently," "university," "Germany," "concerti," "Felicity," "infinity" in "Dream"; "body," "unworthy," "intensively," "minutely," "mobility" in "An Expedient—Leonardo Da Vinci's—And a Query"; "virtuosity," "mentality," "mobility" in "Arthur Mitchell"; "egocentricity," "continuity," "rarity," "delicacy," "fantasy," "jury," "shadowy," "strategy," "biography," "captivity" in "Tell Me, Tell Me." "Old Amusement Park" begins with: "Hurry, worry, unwary / visitor, never vary"—words which seem to have been chosen by the poet for their sound nearly as much as their sense.

In other poems sound almost takes precedence over sense, or at least assumes just as great an importance as sense: "Hometown Piece for Messrs. Alston and Reese," "Enough," "To Victor Hugo of My Crow Pluto," "Rescue with Yul Brynner," and "I've Been Thinking . . ." (published as "Avec Ardeur" in the 1981 edition of *The Complete Poems*). And within other poems, like "Saint Valentine," the rhyme of "vignette," "vinelet" and "violet," and "8" with "fate" suggests *sound* as a guiding principle for poetic choice.

"Efforts of Affection" takes the "-tion" sound of the last word in

to the aural in the later poems. Forced to rely on her "ear" to find English equivalents for the sounds of La Fontaine's end-rhymes in fables which contain few visual metaphors or similes, she was seduced by her method of translation into exercising a rhyming faculty that was different from what she had practiced in those poems for which Eliot cited her as "the greatest living master" of the light rhyme.

As I said before, the rhymes in her later poems sound like the rhymes she uses in her *Fables*. And in at least one poem, "Old Amusement Park," she repeats a rhyme ("elephant" and "aslant") created for her translation of the "The Rat and the Elephant" (Book Eight, XV):

A mite of a rat was mocking an elephant
As it moved slowly by, majestically aslant,
("The Rat and the Elephant")

where crowds flock to the tramcar
rattling greenish caterpillar,
as bowling-ball thunder
quivers the air. The park's elephant
slowly lies down aslant;
("Old Amusement Park")

This off-rhyme, or near-rhyme, was created by Marianne Moore to translate:

Un Rat des plus petits voyait un Éléphant
Des plus gros, et raillait le marcher un peu lent.

Obviously, "aslant" is not a literal rendering of "un peu lent," but an imaginative suggestion in English of the original end-rhyme. The English rhyme resurfaces in this later poem as a direct result of her encounter with La Fontaine's fable.

In addition to exercising her "ear," the experience of translating La Fontaine's fables gave Marianne Moore some felicitous phrases which she incorporated into her later poems. For example, in "Apparition of Splendor" she quotes part of a line from "The Hedgehog, The Fox and The Flies" (Book Twelve, XIII). "With the forest for nurse" is from a line created by Moore in the act of translation: "All over spines, with the forest for nurse." This visual description is not in the French, "Un hérisson du voisinage, / Dans mes vers nouveau personnage."

"Blessed Is the Man" uses more lines from her translation of "The Companions of Ulysses" (Book Twelve, I) than she actually encloses in quotation marks. The later poem says:

Alas, Ulysses' companions are now political—
living self-indulgently until the moral sense is drowned,

having lost all power of comparison,
thinking license emancipates one, "slaves whom they
themselves have bound."

Her translation of the fable reads:

Great and small unanimously
Would range the woods and live self-indulgently
Till the moral sense was drowned.
They had lost all power of comparison
And thinking that license emancipates one,
Were slaves whom they themselves had bound.

This particular passage is, again, not a literal reading of the French. "Till the moral sense was drowned" represents a comment by the translator on La Fontaine's meaning:

Autant le grand que le petit.
La liberté, les bois, suivre leur appétit,
C'était leurs délices suprêmes:
Tous renonçaient au lot des belles actions.
Ils croyaient s'affranchir, suivant leurs passions:
ils étaient esclaves d'eux-mêmes.

Her response to La Fontaine's fable impressed itself sympathetically upon her consciousness, so much so that she remembered it and re-stated it in "Blessed Is the Man."

Besides quoting actual lines from her translations, Moore makes reference to the *Fables* in other ways in her later poems. "Then the Ermine" mentions "Master Corbo in full dress" as an example of the color the poet is trying to describe, "'ebony violet.'" In her translation of "The Fox and The Crow" (Book One, II), it is Master Crow who is greeted by the fox with: "Aha, superb Sir Ebony, well met. / How black! who else boasts your metallic jet!" And "an exhilarating hoarse crow-note" reminds us that in the fable the fox used flattery on the crow, comparing his voice with that of "nightingales." But the "hoarse crow-note" is "exhilarating" because it is real, genuine. Despite the fox's rhetoric, the voice of the crow is unchanged. This allusion to the La Fontaine fable is skillfully worked into the texture and meaning of the poem.

"Efforts of Affection," which was written during her work on the

Fables, may owe some of its form as well as its meaning to her translations. The rhythm of the opening lines—"Genesis tells us of Jubal and Jabal. / One handled the harp and one herded the cattle"—sounds very much like the distinction between the swan and the goose in Moore's translation of "The Swan and the Cook" (Book Three, XII). "A swan swam, and a goose waddled: . . . / . . . One enhanced the flowers; one stayed near the house and puddled." "Efforts of Affection," a poem about integration of opposites, goes on to use La Fontaine in a series of comparisons:

Love's extraordinary-ordinary stubbornness
Like La Fontaine's done
by each as if by each alone,
smiling and stemming distraction;

"Like La Fontaine's" is vague, but in the context of the poem's other references it seems to be La Fontaine's love matches. Towards the end of the poem, Moore says that "love can make one / bestial or make a beast a man," which contains an allusion to "The Lion in Love" (Book Four, I). In order to become more man-like in his wooing of the shepherdess, the lion is tricked into clipping its claws and filing down its teeth—thus losing its lion-ness and its life.

"In Lieu of the Lyre" was written in response to a request from the president of the Harvard *Advocate* for a poem. It celebrates the poet's affiliation with that institution through her association with Professor Harry Levin who provided substantive help with the *Fables*. From 1948 on, Levin was mainly responsible for checking Moore's reading of the French and often suggested alternate words and phrases which he felt came closer to the literal meaning of the original. His continuous help and support were no doubt the most important resources outside of her own talents that she had. Her gratitude is evident in all the correspondence which ensued in what became a lifelong friendship, but she must have chafed under his tutelage at times.

The subject and feeling of "In Lieu of the Lyre" are both consequences of the nine years' struggle with the *Fables*. Although "debarred from enrollment at Harvard," Moore thereafter referred to herself as Levin's Harvard student even though she was considerably older than her tutor. She claims that Professor Levin "invented" her French aspect in his essay, "On Her French Aspect," and teasingly records for posterity the professor's outrage over the sloppy editing of Tambimuttu in the *Festschrift* celebrating her seventy-seventh birthday.²⁰

Professor Levin,
a too outspoken outraged refugee from clichés particularly,
who was proffered redress
by the Lowell House Press—
Vermont Stinehour Press, rather. (No careless statements
to Kirkland House; least of all inexactness in quoting a fact.)

The satire of early poems like "To a Steam Roller" and "To Statecraft Embalmed" has mellowed and become more urbane in the later poems. Here fastidiousness appreciated can also be humorously deprecated.

"I've Been Thinking" is another poem which alludes in both its subject and form to her work on the translations. Published as "Avec Ardeur" in the 1981 edition of *The Complete Poems* and dedicated to Pound—"Dear Ezra, who knows what cadence is," the poem dwells on the "word diseases" of the poet-translator—the hard choices, the conflicts between sound and sense. "Avec Ardeur" is part of the title of a poem by Madame Boufflers (1711–1786), "Sentir avec ardeur," which appears in the first stanza of "In Lieu of the Lyre."

animated by Madame de Boufflers' choice rhymes:
Sentir avec ardeur; with fire; yes, with passion;
rime-prose revived also by word-wizard Achilles—
Dr. Fang.

The need for passion in her translations haunted Moore who believed that they should imitate La Fontaine's form as well as his meaning, but "not sound like" translations. Her self-imposed poetics of translation (reproducing whenever possible the same number of lines as the French fable, similar line lengths, La Fontaine's rhyme pattern and even the sounds of his end-rhymes) were in direct conflict with the equally strong conviction that translations should be as fresh and spontaneous as original poems.

Marianne Moore had asked Ezra Pound for "help" in 1948, concerned that her ear might not be good.²¹ Although Pound's involvement with the fables was less than that of Harry Levin, he was a figure of such stature as a poet and translator that Moore took his suggestions very seriously. Pound mainly concerned himself with syntax, recommending the natural order of words in English: subject, predicate, object, and the use of active verbs when possible. But one comment of Pound's on a manuscript of "The Lion, the Wolf and the Fox" (Book Eight, III) suggests that she might, as a poet-translator, try to find more fun in rhymes.²²

Finding more fun in rhymes is what the poet is about in much of

her later poetry, that "wordcraft irresistible." Moore's nine-year encounter with the French fables was a transforming experience for both La Fontaine and his translator, one which called for a different approach to writing poetry. Any assessment of Moore's later poems must take this into account. The poems she wrote during and after her work on the fables are not quite the same as the ones she wrote before, although the observation she made about Thomas Hardy is certainly as true of herself: "It is not Hardy the novelist / and Hardy the poet, but one man interpreting life as emotion."²³ It is not Marianne Moore, the poet, and Marianne Moore, the translator, but one integrated, unique sensibility interpreting life as she lived it—at different times. The later poems incorporate her experiences as a translator as well as actual lines from her translations; they are more characteristic of what she called "straight writing"; and they appeal to the ear, employing end rhymes reminiscent of the ones she invented in order to reproduce La Fontaine's in English. It is the same poet, but a slightly different poetics than that which shapes and informs the earlier poems.

All previously unpublished material by Marianne Moore is used with the Permission of Clive E. Driver, Literary Executor of the Estate of Marianne C. Moore.

¹ *Nation*, June 19, 1954, p. 525.

² *The New Yorker*, Oct. 16, 1978, p. 188.

³ *The Poet's Advance* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton Univ. Press, 1978), p. 160.

⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 183.

⁵ "Supreme in Her Abnormality," *Poetry*, 84 (Sept., 1954), 363.

⁶ *New York World Journal Tribune*, Oct. 30, 1966.

⁷ *After Babel: Aspects of Language and Translation* (N.Y. and London: Oxford Univ. Press, 1975), p. 350.

⁸ *Marianne Moore: Imaginary Possessions* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard Univ. Press, 1981), p. 13.

⁹ *Selected Poems* (New York: Macmillan, 1935), p. 36.

¹⁰ "Interview with Donald Hall," in *A Marianne Moore Reader* (New York: Viking, 1961), p. 259.

¹¹ "Jerboas, Pelicans and Pee Wee Reese," in *Book Week*, 4, 8 (Oct. 30, 1966).

¹² *The Poet's Advance*, pp. 186–212.

¹³ This music box is in residence at the Rosenbach Museum and Library. According to Patricia Willis, Curator of the Marianne Moore Collection at the Rosenbach, Gladys Berry, Moore's housekeeper, recalled this in connection with Moore's lending the box to her housekeeper's children.

¹⁴ Music Notebook, 1932–1954. See Rosenbach 1251/18.

¹⁵ "Introduction," *Selected Poems* (New York: Macmillan, 1935), p. xiii.

¹⁶ *Nation*, 170 (25 February 1950), p. 181.

¹⁷ George W. Nitchie, *Marianne Moore: An Introduction to the Poetry* (New York: Columbia Univ. Press, 1969), p. 150.

¹⁸ Marianne Moore, "The Past is the Present," *Selected Poems*, p. 103.

¹⁹ "He 'Digesteth Harde Yron,'" in *What Are Years* (New York: Macmillan, 1941), p. 8.

²⁰ A corrected reprint of the essay was later published in Harry Levin's *Grounds for Comparison* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard Univ. Press, 1972).

²¹ Carbon typescript. Letter from Marianne Moore to Ezra Pound, May 26, 1948 in the unpublished papers and correspondence of Marianne Moore at the Rosenbach Museum and Library in Philadelphia.

²² Typescript. See drafts of *Fables* in unpublished papers and correspondence. The Rosenbach.

²³ "Picking and Choosing," *The Complete Poems* (New York: Macmillan / Viking, 1967), p. 45.